

Artificial Urinary Sphincter (AUS)

Patient Information · What to expect before your AUS surgery

WARWIKI

An artificial urinary sphincter (AUS) is a small device placed completely under your skin. It helps control urine leakage, most often leakage after prostate surgery. You work it yourself with a pump hidden in the scrotum.

About This Procedure

Leaking urine when you cough, lift or move is called **stress incontinence**. An AUS treats it with three connected parts, all under the skin:

- A soft **cuff** around the urethra (the tube urine flows through). It squeezes the urethra closed to keep you dry.
- A **pump** in the scrotum that you press when you want to urinate
- A small **balloon** in the lower belly that sets the pressure

How you use it: the cuff stays closed most of the time. When you need to urinate, squeeze and release the pump a few times. The cuff opens and you urinate. A few minutes later it closes again on its own.

Benefits and Risks in Numbers

about
8 in 10

men use no pad or just 1 pad a day afterward

about
2 to 4 in 100

get an infection after a first implant, which usually means the device must come out

about
6 in 10

have not needed another operation 5 years later

Numbers are averages from published studies. Your own risk may differ; ask your team.

What to Know Before You Decide

- **Most men are much better, but not always fully dry.** More than 8 in 10 are satisfied.
- **More surgery is common over the years.** The device can wear out, or the urethra can thin under the cuff. About 4 to 6 in 10 men need a repair or new device within 10 years.
- Risks, including infection, are higher after radiation, earlier urethra surgery or removal of an earlier sphincter.

Learn the Terms

Stress incontinence

Leaking urine when you cough, lift or move.

Urethra

The tube that carries urine out of the body.

Cuff

The part that squeezes the urethra closed to keep you dry.

Pump

The part in the scrotum you press to open the cuff.

Activation

Turning the device on at a visit about 4 to 6 weeks after surgery.

Deactivation

Turning the device off so the cuff stays open. This is needed before any catheter.

Erosion

When the cuff wears into the urethra. It needs another operation.

Cystoscopy

A camera check of the urethra and bladder, often done before surgery.

Will it hurt? You will be asleep or numb from the waist down, so you feel nothing during surgery. Afterward, expect soreness, swelling and bruising of the scrotum and the area behind it for a couple of weeks. Many people go home the same day.

Weeks 1–2

Swelling and bruising. Support, ice and pain medicine.

Until activation

The device is off, so you still leak. Use pads. Do not press the pump.

Weeks 4–6

Activation visit. You learn to use the pump.

For life

Tell every provider you have an AUS.

How to Get Ready

- Follow your surgery instructions about eating, drinking and which medicines to stop, including blood thinners.
- Preventing infection matters most.** A urine test checks for infection, and any infection is treated first. You will wash with antiseptic soap and get antibiotics.
- Stop smoking and vaping.**

Tell your team ahead of time if you:

- Have had **radiation** to the pelvis, or earlier urethra or leakage surgery
- Have **diabetes**, or trouble using your hands (you work the pump yourself)

What Happens During Surgery

- You get general or spinal anesthesia and antibiotics.
- Through small cuts, the surgeon places the cuff, balloon and pump, all under the skin.
- The device is filled and tested, then **left turned off** so you can heal.

After Surgery

- Until activation, avoid pressure on the area behind the scrotum, such as a bike seat. Your team will tell you when you can lift, exercise and have sex.
- Always tell any provider you have an AUS.** It must be turned off before any catheter, or the urethra can be hurt. Carry your implant card.

Call the office that did your surgery if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Redness, swelling or pain that is getting worse, or fluid leaking from a cut
- New blood in your urine, or leaking that suddenly gets worse

Go to an emergency department if:

- You cannot urinate at all
- The scrotum becomes very swollen, hard or very painful
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

- An AUS greatly improves leakage for most men, though you may not be fully dry.
- It stays off for about 4 to 6 weeks. You will still leak until it is turned on.
- No catheter may be passed until the device is turned off. Show your implant card.